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ACTOR PART BOOK

# Player 3

*the youngest, and the curious one*

*Six Characters in Search of an Author*

*Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922*

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

**17 SPEECHES · 164 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY**

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## WHO PLAYER 3 IS

**Player 3 may be played by a young man or a young woman — the part is written for either.** These notes use *they*; the director should settle on the pronoun that fits the actor cast, and adjust the few stage directions that carry it.

Carries the Juvenile Lead, the Prompter, An Actor, and the Fifth Actor. **In their early twenties — the youngest in the company by a good ten years.** First proper season at the Village Players, after a few small parts last year and a drama school in Geneva that they still mention when they are nervous. They are not yet sure whether they are an actor or a person who is currently acting. **They are also, without question, the happiest person in the building** — they still cannot quite believe they are being paid (a little) to spend their evenings inside a theatre — and they do a bit of everything: prompt from the box, read the small parts, help strike the set, run for the props nobody else will fetch. No job is beneath them, because all of it is theatre, and theatre is the thing they love. The audience reads their age the moment they enter: the body is younger, the listening is sharper, the eyes track the older two to learn what one does.

Their dominant register is *curious*. Where Player 1 has opinions and Player 2 has shoulders, Player 3 has questions. When the Six arrive they are the first to take them seriously — not because they believe the Father's philosophy, but because they have never seen a rehearsal interrupted in this way and they want to know what happens. They lean forward. They nod. They catch themselves nodding and try to stop. The other two notice; they colour. **The notebook is their tell:** they write everything down — lines, phrases, things they do not yet understand but suspect they are meant to keep — and the moment they stop writing is the moment the play has stopped being a curiosity and become something they would rather not have on record.

The arc to score: in Act One they are enthralled by the strangers and slightly embarrassed by their own enthrallment — the one Player who keeps watching when the others are still cracking wise. In Act Two they stop finding it funny; the pencil goes still. By Act Three they are the Player who has understood the play the company has stumbled into — the conscience who asks whether someone should stop this, and waits, and is not answered. Their face is the audience's mirror at every horror in the second half.

They play four roles. The **Juvenile Lead** is eager and slightly ridiculous — they have been told they have "stage presence" and have heard it as *promise*. The **Prompter** is them in a wooden box, frowning at the draught and the shorthand, pleased to be useful, faintly aware they are too young for the role and trying to compensate with seriousness. **An Actor** and the **Fifth Actor** are functions: someone has to read a line. They read them clean, no pretension, and look to Player 2 to check they did it right.

The casting note for the audition room: the actor — of any gender — must be young enough that the age difference reads from the back row, and a sharp enough listener that the company's whole second half can be tracked on their face. The audience must believe both that this is the youngest person in the room and that they are the one who understands soonest what the company has stumbled into. That is the role's range.

## THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

**What it is.** Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

**This production.** Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen**. One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

**How it opens.** The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: the Door-keeper carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

## HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Where the role doubles a function, the function is printed beside the line (*as Prompter*, and so on); chorus lines the company speaks together keep their group tag (*All Three Players*). Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

# Act One — The Family

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## PART I *The Rehearsal*

4 SPEECHES · 66 WORDS

**CUE** *Player 1:* During me. There's a difference.

**PLAYER 3** [*reading the "book"*]. "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

**CUE** *Player 2:* ... sir? Hope? Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

**PLAYER 3** [*reading from the "book"*]. "When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, in cook's cap and apron, is busy beating an egg in a cup..."

**CUE** *The Manager:* ... always noted. Chair, book — and somebody pretend we are a theatre.

**PLAYER 3.** Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they've still not mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

**CUE** *The Manager:* Yes, yes — in, in.

**PLAYER 3** [*pausing at the box, half to himself*]. Do we ever rehearse anything real?

## PART II *The Interruption*

2 SPEECHES · 8 WORDS

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

**PLAYER 3** [*coming forward from the others*]. Oh — do you hear that?

**CUE** *Player 2:* We are the audience this time.

**PLAYER 3** [*quietly, the pencil not moving*]. For once. [*Nobody laughs.*]

## PART III *The Bargain*

3 SPEECHES · 15 WORDS

**CUE** *Player 1:* ... six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

**PLAYER 3.** They are not ordinary strangers.

**CUE** *Player 1:* ... wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes.

**PLAYER 3.** Perhaps there is a play.

**CUE** *Player 1:* They looked expected.

**PLAYER 3.** Am I taking this down?

# Act Two — The Theatre

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## PART I *The Setup*

4 SPEECHES · 31 WORDS

| **CUE** *The Son*: ... apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

**PLAYER 3** [*very quietly, the pencil gone still in their hand*]. *Mon Dieu*. I've stopped writing it down. I don't want a record of this one.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... I'm going to ask you to do something out of the ordinary.

**PLAYER 3** [*looking up from the book; an unusual request to receive at this hour*]. Take it down in shorthand? Sir — *in shorthand*?

| **CUE** *The Manager*: Exactly! Can you do shorthand?

**PLAYER 3**. Yes, a little.

| **CUE** *Player 2*: Why our hats?

**PLAYER 3**. Are we still rehearsing?

## PART II *The Apparition*

2 SPEECHES · 17 WORDS

| **CUE** *Player 1*: What's going to happen next? Have we lost the script entirely?

**PLAYER 3**. Where did *she* come from? She wasn't here a moment ago. She wasn't anywhere.

| **CUE** *Player 1*: What does she say? Madame — speak up.

**PLAYER 3**. Louder! Louder please!

## PART III *The Substitution*

PLAYER 3 DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

# Act Three — The Question

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## PART I    *The Trap*

PLAYER 3 DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

## PART II    *The Refusal*

1 SPEECH · 20 WORDS

**CUE**    *The Father:* ... him? We've all tried him in turn — I, she and she.

**PLAYER 3** *[to no one in particular — the youngest voice in the room].* Should we — should someone — stop this? I keep waiting for one of you to say that we should. *[No one does.]*

## PART III    *The Fountain*

1 SPEECH · 7 WORDS

**CUE**    *The Son:* What do you want?

**PLAYER 3.** Nothing! I was just looking at you.